

Ola Hop: shared autos, cabs and buses that run like a metro

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Live prototype: ola-hop.vercel.app

1. Executive summary

Thesis: shared transport in Indian cities is not short of vehicles. It is unorganised. Nobody can see an auto coming, know where it is going or trust its price, so people wait, haggle, and buy their own vehicle as soon as they can afford one. Ola should organise its autos, cabs and partner buses into fixed lines, with a vehicle every 4 minutes at peak and a fixed fare per seat, the way a metro runs.

I would start with one line on Bengaluru's Outer Ring Road, treat it as an experiment, and expand only if riders get a vehicle within 5 minutes and drivers earn more per hour.

2. The problem

People who rely on shared transport in Bengaluru describe it like this:

"some days the bus I need doesn't turn up for 40 minutes"

Bus commuter, Citizen Matters, 2016¹

"Meter illa", "Cancel sir", "Cash only"

Typical auto replies, listed by a commuter new to Bengaluru, Asianet Newsable²

"I had to get my own vehicle since finding cabs and autos in this area is challenging."

IT employee in Bellandur, on the Outer Ring Road, The South First³

"the auto was moving at a very slow pace, which terrified me"

20-year-old student travelling at night, The News Minute⁴

Surveys show the same at scale. Of 10,948 ride-hailing users who answered a LocalCircles question on cancellations, 84% had rides cancelled because of their destination or because they wanted to pay digitally⁵. Of about 1,800 residents surveyed along Sarjapur Road and the Outer Ring Road, around 900 spend one to two hours on the road every day, and many said they would switch to buses if they came often enough⁶.

I also spoke to five people who commute daily, asking how they get to work, what bothers them, and what would make shared rides better.

	How they get to work	What they said
P1	Walks 5 minutes, takes a bus, then looks for an auto	"Waste of time." Wants it to be simple.
P2	Books Rapido	Sometimes no driver accepts the ride. Thought a fixed line "maybe useful".
P3	Office cab	Takes too long to reach the office.
P4	Own vehicle	No complaints.
P5	Two autos	Expensive, and drivers "demand too much".

Four of the five stitch together trips that are slow, uncertain or overpriced. The only person without a complaint had left shared transport and bought a vehicle. Bengaluru already has 1.2 crore registered vehicles and adds about 2,100 every day⁷.

3. Root cause analysis

Hypothesis	Confidence	Reasoning
H1: Shared transport is unorganised, so riders can't plan around it	High	P1, P2 and P3 all lose time to uncertainty. Where someone does organise it, people use it: the HSR Layout feeder bus grew from about 300 to over 6,000 riders a day ⁸ , and Chennai runs about 60,000 share autos on informal routes ⁹ .
H2: Unpredictable prices and refusals push riders away	High	84% of surveyed users faced cancellations ⁵ ; P5 says drivers demand too much.
H3: Safety after dark limits how much women use shared rides	Medium	Strong individual accounts ⁴ , but no Bengaluru-wide data on how many women avoid shared rides at night.
H4: People leave shared transport for their own vehicle once they can afford it	Needs validation	Consistent with P4 and the Bellandur quote ³ , but five conversations are not proof.

H1 is the upstream cause. H2 and H3 make it worse, and H4 is the outcome Ola should want to reverse: every rider who gives up adds a vehicle to the road.

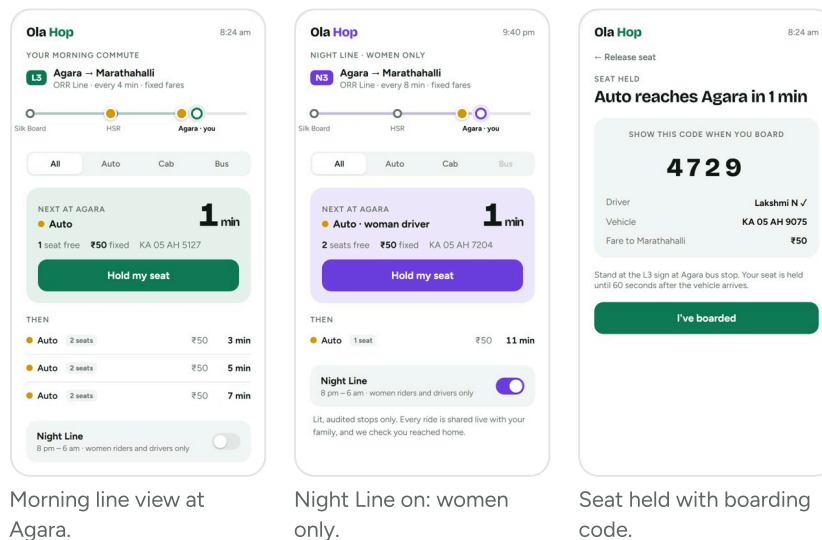
4. Why it matters by 2035

Indian cities will hold about 60.4 crore people by 2036, up from 51.8 crore today¹⁰. India runs about 65,000 organised city buses for all of them, and more than 400 cities have none¹¹. Metro helps but is slow and costly: 1,095 km across 26 cities so far, at about ₹327 crore per km¹². Bengaluru's metro took 15 years to reach 96 km¹³, and the Outer Ring Road, where 6 to 10 lakh people work¹⁴, has no line open yet: the Blue Line is now expected in 2027²⁵. Autos and cabs already carry the people that buses and metro can't, and Ola can organise them far faster than anyone can build track. Hop is not a rival to the metro. As track opens, lines shift to feeding its stations, so by 2035 most Hop trips should start or end at a metro or bus stop.

5. Proposed solution: Ola Hop

Who it's for. Riders like Priya, 26, a software tester on the Outer Ring Road with no vehicle of her own, for whom a daily cab costs more than ₹6,000 a month. Drivers like Lakshmi, 38, who drives an Ola e-auto ten hours a day and loses much of it driving empty between bookings. I am leaving out intercity travel and occasional riders: daily commuters make two trips a day, and that repetition builds the habit.

How it works. Ola draws a line where its trip data shows many people travelling the same way, and assigns autos, cabs and partner buses to run it. The rider sees the next vehicles coming to their stop with type, minutes, free seats and fare, holds a seat, and boards with a 4-digit code. Fares are fixed per seat for an 8 to 12 km trip (₹25 bus, ₹50 auto, ₹80 cab) and never surge. A full auto earns ₹150, close to one solo fare, while each rider pays a third.



Night Line. A switch on the same line. From 8 pm to 6 am it shows only women drivers, uses only lit stops, shares every ride live with family and checks that the rider reached home. On every ride, drivers are police-verified, each vehicle carries an Ola GPS unit with a panic button, and the app alerts Ola if a vehicle leaves its line.

6. Key choices, and why not the alternatives

I chose	Instead of	Because
Fixed lines	On-demand pooling, like Ola Share	The people I spoke to lose time to uncertainty. A vehicle you can see coming fixes that; waiting to be matched does not.
Only Ola vehicles	Showing every vehicle on the road	Ola can only promise safety, fares and timing for vehicles it controls.
Rider picks auto, cab or bus	Ola assigning a vehicle	People trade price against speed differently each day.
Night Line as a switch	A separate women's product	Same line, same app. Easier to find and easier to run.
Even gaps between vehicles	Fixed clock times	Outer Ring Road traffic breaks any timetable. A vehicle every 4 minutes still holds when everything is slow.
Fixed fares that never surge	Dynamic pricing	Refusals and haggling are the top complaint (H2). A known price is the point.
Outer Ring Road first	Electronic City	The densest office commute, with no metro until 2027. When the Blue Line opens, L3 becomes feeder lines to its stations. Electronic City already has the Yellow Line.

Why not robotaxis or an AI matching engine first. By 2035 it is tempting to lead with autonomous vehicles or smarter matching. I deliberately did not. The evidence points to an organisation problem, not an intelligence problem. Lines drawn by hand from Ola's trip data can test the idea in weeks. Automatic line planning becomes useful once lines are proven, to draw and redraw them across hundreds of cities.

Why this time is different. Ola has tried this before. Ola Shuttle, its fixed-route bus service, shut in 2018, and in Bengaluru its vehicles were seized because only BMTC holds a permit to sell seats on a fixed route²¹. Karnataka called Ola Share illegal in 2017²², and Uber closed its last Shuttle city in March 2026²³. Hop differs in three ways: it uses autos and cabs already on the road instead of buses, which proved costly for both Ola and Uber; the aggregator guidelines now allow pooling, including women-only rides²⁰; and buses join only through operators that hold permits, starting with BMTC. The open risk is Karnataka, whose rules still don't define pooling. The MVP waits for written approval, and if it doesn't come, the first line moves to the first state that adopts the central pooling rules.

7. MVP as an experiment

Element	Detail
Hypothesis	If Ola runs a fixed line with a vehicle every 4 minutes and fixed fares, Outer Ring Road commuters will use it at least three days a week, and drivers will earn more per hour than on regular bookings.
Setup	Line L3, Silk Board to Marathahalli, with Night Line in the evenings. About 40 Ola autos and cabs (12 with women drivers) and 5 partner buses. 12 weeks.
Primary metric	Daily rides where the rider waited 5 minutes or less.
Secondary metrics	Riders using it 3+ days a week, paying riders per trip, driver earnings per hour, Night Line rides.
Guardrails	Safety incidents and SOS response time, lost held seats, Ola cab bookings on the same corridor.
Decision rule	Scale if, by week 12, median peak wait is 5 minutes or less, about 3,000 rides a day, 4 in 10 riders use it 3+ days a week, drivers earn about 15% more per hour, and no serious safety incident is unresolved. Otherwise fix and rerun, or stop.

Unit economics (my estimates). Will drivers really earn more? Only if seats stay full.

	Solo auto, by meter	Hop auto on L3
One trip	9 km at ₹36 + ₹18 a km = ₹162 ²⁴	11 km run at ₹50 a seat
Time	About 35 min riding, plus about 10 min to reach the next rider	About 42 min with stops; the next run starts at the last stop
Per hour	About ₹215	About ₹215 with 3 riders, about ₹180 with 2.5; more only when seats are resold at stops

So seat fill, not price, decides supply. Paying riders per run is the first number I would watch; if it stays below 3, I would raise the auto fare to ₹60 or shorten the line. Ola earns the same daily driver subscription it charges today (₹67 a day¹⁷),

so fares go fully to drivers, plus a share of partner-bus tickets and monthly passes. At 30 lakh drivers, subscriptions alone are about ₹7,300 crore a year.

8. Prioritisation

Priority	Initiative	Why now
P0	Line view, seat hold, fixed fares, driver app	The core promise: a vehicle within 5 minutes at a known price.
P0	Safety features and Night Line	One serious incident would end trust; women are the riders most affected (H3).
P1	Leave-now alerts and a monthly pass	Turn a good line into a daily habit once it works.
P2	More lines and feeder lines to metro stations	Grow coverage, after the first line proves density and driver earnings.
Defer	Automatic line planning, trips across two lines	High effort; only worth it once hand-drawn lines are proven. A sequencing call, not a rejection.

9. Metrics

Type	Metric	Why
North star	Daily rides with a wait of 5 minutes or less	Counts usage and the promise together. Adding riders faster than vehicles pushes waits up and stops it growing.
Habit	Riders using Hop 3+ days a week	Daily commuting is the whole bet.
Supply	Driver earnings per hour	If drivers don't earn more, lines lose vehicles.
Guardrails	Safety incidents per 10 lakh rides; SOS answered within 60 s; Ola cab bookings	A fake win would be rides going up while cab bookings fall by the same amount: that is moving riders, not adding them.

10. Getting to 10 crore users

That is about one in six city residents in 2036. If they ride about 4 days a week, that is 5.7 crore riders and 11.4 crore trips a day. An auto or cab doing 12 runs a day with about 3 riders gives 36 trips, so 30 lakh vehicles give about 10.8 crore, and 1 lakh buses at about 300 trips a day add 3 crore. The plan closes, but only if vehicles run nearly full all day. It needs a vehicle every 4 to 5 minutes on every line (a line opens only when enough vehicles are assigned), drivers earning more per hour (guaranteed for each new line's first 8 weeks), about 30 lakh Ola autos and cabs plus 1 lakh partner buses out of 2.35 crore expected gig workers¹⁵, and riders who trust it. After Bengaluru, the next cities are Pune, Hyderabad and Gurugram, which have the same tech-corridor problem. Then tier-2 cities such as Indore, Lucknow and Coimbatore, where many residents have no city bus at all and Hop could become the main public transport. Path: one line in 2027, three cities in 2028, ten cities and 1.5 crore users by 2030, 10 crore across 200+ cities by 2035. Supply is the part I am least sure of.

11. Why Ola

Ola has its own maps since 2024¹⁶, a driver subscription that Ola says more than 10 lakh drivers have joined¹⁷, with autos at the centre, and Ola Electric to build GPS and panic buttons into new autos. It also needs a new direction: it is third by monthly users, behind Rapido and Uber¹⁸, and its consumer revenue fell 42% in FY25²⁶. Hop suits that position because it is capital-light: it runs on vehicles, drivers and maps Ola already has. A network of lines is a category it can lead instead of a price war it is losing.

12. First 90 days

Window	Focus
Day 0 to 30	Draw L3 from Ola trip data; recruit and fit GPS in 40 vehicles; sign 1 bus partner; 12 rider and 8 driver interviews on the corridor.
Day 30 to 60	Launch L3 with Night Line; watch wait times and bunching daily; adjust vehicle count and stop locations.
Day 60 to 90	Read the experiment against the decision rule; decide scale, fix or stop; if scaling, pick the next 3 lines.

Questions I would ask in those interviews: What do you do when the vehicle you expected doesn't come? What would make you trust a shared ride at night? What would it take for you to leave your own vehicle at home? For drivers: how much do you earn on a good hour, and what makes an hour bad?

13. Assumptions

1. City populations follow the government projection of 60.4 crore by 2036¹⁰.
2. By 2035, public service vehicles carry working GPS and panic buttons, as the Supreme Court ordered in 2026¹⁹.
3. Pooling and women-only rides with women drivers are allowed under MoRTH's aggregator guidelines, as amended in December 2025, and states adopt them²⁰.
4. Bus operators will share live GPS with Ola in return for ticket sales and ridership data.
5. Drivers on lines drive only for Ola and accept an Ola-installed GPS unit.
6. Fares, fleet sizes and the growth path are my estimates, to be tested in the MVP.

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